

Galapagos tortoise

Chelonoidis nigra



The Galapagos tortoise is famous both for its enormous size and for being one of the world's longest-lived animals. Six of the Galapagos Islands are home to 14 different kinds of this giant land reptile. Some experts regard them as subspecies or races; others class them as separate species in view of genetic studies. However, the Galapagos tortoise can be split into two types based on the shape of the shell. These are the large “domed” type, which have big, round shells, and the slightly smaller “saddleback”, with an arched or saddlelike flare in the shell above the neck. This arch may be an adaptation to feeding in more arid habitats, where vegetation—such as the prickly pear cactus, a favorite food—is higher off the ground and can only be reached by craning the head and neck.

Partial migrators

On some islands, when the dry season begins, older males and some adult females leave the lowlands for the more humid highlands. It takes them two to three weeks

to migrate about 4 miles (6km), and they remain in the highlands until the rains return. The rest of the tortoises stay in the lowlands all year. The Galapagos tortoise's unhurried lifestyle, slow metabolism, and ability to store food energy and water mean it can survive for a whole year without eating or drinking if it has to.

Traditional nesting sites

Mating peaks from February to May—the rainy season—when the male becomes territorial and starts to sniff, pursue, nip, and ram the female. Female tortoises usually choose a traditional site near the coast and dig a hole in loose soil or sand to lay the eggs. She lays up to four clutches of between five and 18 eggs (the average is eight to 10 per clutch), then fills in the hole. The eggs take from four to eight months to hatch, depending on the temperature, and the babies may spend several days, even weeks, digging their way up to the surface. The eggs and hatchlings are threatened by introduced predators such as cats and black rats.

Galapagos tortoises are **exceptionally long-lived**, with **one female** living more than **170 years**

◁ SADDLEBACK SHELL

Galapagos tortoises have long, flexible necks. The above-neck flare of the shells of tortoises on the drier Española Island allows them to reach taller plants.

▷ DOMED SHELL

Domed-shelled tortoises are generally less territorial and more social. They often rest in groups or herds, in earthen scrapes called pallets.



- ↔ Up to 4 ft (1.2m)
- ⚖ Up to 660 lb (300 kg)
- ⊗ Vulnerable
- 🌿 Cacti, grass, leaves, berries
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